

Extremist Populism and Labor Unions: Investigating the Black Legion's Impact on Union Participation

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1 Overview

The interwar period in the United States was one of great social and economic upheaval. Following the first world war, the global economy boomed, with American markets leading much of the growth. The Great Depression then brought this boom period to an abrupt end, plunging the country into destitution. Conjointly, there was much social change, with social equity and racial parity topics of discussion. We saw the Great Migration, where black Americans left the South in search of opportunity elsewhere. While some fought for such change and championed the transition from Civil War-era race relations towards more modern ones, many were not prepared for such a shift. From this, we saw a boom in populist-fascist ideology and groups. The Ku-Klux-Klan returned after a hiatus of approximately 30 years, the advent of the radio brought about voices like Father Coughlin or Huey Long to the forefront. Much of their rhetoric was anti-semitic, anti-black, and anti-immigration.

A smaller group from this period were the Black Legion, primarily focused in Detroit and Fort Wayne, Michigan. An offshoot of the Klan, the Black Legion were formed by Dr. William Shepard in Ohio as a group which celebrated the ideals of the Antebellum South through rituals and dress. Donning black robes rather than the white of the Klan, the Black Legion were a love letter to these conservative ideas to which Shepard was so attached. However, in 1932, leadership changes brought the group from one which was primarily ritualistic, towards being more prone to action. Virgil Effinger, the new leader, as well as Isaac White, a member who was well-positioned at Ford Motor Company, overhauled the operation's recruiting and modus operandi. Attacks on union leaders and political opponents took place throughout the 1930's and 1940's, before in 1942, the group attempted to bomb the mayor of a nearby town called Ecorse. This attempted attack led to the New York Times writing an article on them.

The timing of this article is of particular interest. From 1932 until the release of the article in 1942, the Black Legion had entrenched themselves into the auto unions and steel unions via high-ranking members at institutions such as the Ford Motor Company. This allowed them to easily recruit new members into their fraternity, and thus grow their numbers.

I want to investigate if there is an effect of the NYT article on union membership. That is, were people avoiding the unions out of concern of Black Legion recruitment, and did the increase in awareness lead to them joining more freely?

2 Data

Using historical union records, I can determine if the union chapters in Detroit and Ft. Wayne changed differently than in other parts of Michigan or the Rust Belt. Using data from 1935-1949, I can have a clean pre and post period. Further, I can supplement by seeing if the effects of other, non-local, populist actors had any effect on union participation. The Klan was also concentrated in certain states, allowing me to check across impacted areas outside of Michigan.

Wayne State University's Archive of Labor and Union Affairs provides detailed records on union

participation in Michigan and the Walter P. Reuther Library. They specifically have many records pertaining to the auto industry, which is key for my analysis of the impact in the Ford Motor Company. Next, following 'The Confederate Diaspora' from Bazzi and authors, I can also get data on the Second Klan for comparative analysis on the impact of populist-fascist groups in general on union participation. This comes from the Virginia Commonwealth Library's Klan Map Project. Importantly, I can use the Peter H. Amann Collection from Wayne State University. Here, I can find all things Black Legion, including arrest records, mentions in union proceedings, and news stories pertaining to the group. Lastly, I do have historical census data on the United States, covering 1789-1945. It includes data on labor, migration, and manufacturing. This could be a good supplement to the more specific data.

3 Methodology

I plan to use a differences-in-differences design, comparing Legion afflicted union chapters with non-afflicted ones. The group was quite concentrated to the Detroit area, with minor chapters in the surrounding Rust Belt. I plan to use the release of the New York Times article as my treatment. That is, I hypothesize that the information diffusion of the Legion activities would impact oversight on union recruiting and membership.

I am also interested in seeing if there is an effect in Klan affected areas in Texas or Georgia. This would allow me to see if this hyper-local group has a statistically different effect on the unions in their area or if this is a symptom of populist-fascist groups infecting a region.

4 Hurdles to Overcome

Ideally, I would begin my analysis in 1932 when Effinger took over from Shepard. This is proving difficult to find data on, with much of the data being stuck at 1935. This is an ongoing search, and I have some leads, but completeness of that data is still TBD.

The estimation design will need to be carefully considered. Again, this time period had a lot of moving parts, so accounting for everything in estimation will be difficult. Help with designs would be appreciated.

Finally, is the question itself too narrow? External validity will obviously be non-existent looking at this hyper-local effect, but there are perhaps ways to broaden it. Help here would also be appreciated.

5 Conclusion

In closing, I think this poses an interesting question which has not been researched: do extremist-populist groups impact more than just crime in a local area? This analysis would exploit the Black Legion's ties to local labor unions to test if there is any impact of the group's presence on union

participation. Despite mild data concerns and research ambiguity, this is a project which excites me and provides a clear contribution to the historical economics and labor economics literature.